The thought of a world without trees became a sort of nightmare to me and I helped Grandfather in his tree-planting with greater enthusiasm. And while we went about our work, he taught me a poem by George Morris:

Woodman, spare that tree!
Touch not a single bough!
In youth it sheltered me,
And I'll protect it now.

'One day the trees will move again,' said Grandfather. 'They've been standing still for thousands of years but there was a time when they could walk about like people. Then along came an interfering busybody who cast a spell over them, rooting them to one place. But they're always trying to move. See how they reach out with their arms! And some of them, like the banyan tree with its travelling aerial roots, manage to get quite far.'

We found an island, a small rocky island in a dry river-bed. It was one of those river-beds so common in the foothills, which are completely dry in summer but flooded during the monsoon rains. A small mango tree was growing on the island. 'If a small tree can grow here.' said Grandfather, 'so can others.' As soon as the rains set in and while rivers could still be crossed, we set out with a number of tamarind, laburnum, and coral tree saplings and cuttings and spent the day planting them on the island.

Do you know

The Western Ghats is home to nearly 325 globally-threatened flora and fauna.

Discuss and answer.

1. Why do we need trees? List four reasons that Grandfather gives.
2. Why did the author help his Grandfather plant trees?
3. What made Grandfather plant saplings on the rocky island?

GLOSSARY

protested	- opposed or disagreed
nightmare	- a frightening dream
interfering	- stopping

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